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1. A matinee and happy hour

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This is basically dinner and a movie in reverse. By simply switching the order and time of day you do this, your cash outlay reduces dramatically. Depending on what time in the afternoon you go, you might even have time for a double feature. Then check out your local eateries and see what happy hour deals your favorite places offer. With both entertainment and food at such a discount, you're able to keep the date under budget even if you want to indulge a little more.

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2. Share a foot-long

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Some popular sandwich chains offer 12-inch subs for \$5. Get the meal deal, go easy on the ice in the drink, and take it to a scenic spot for a more modern version of the scene from *Lady and the Tramp*. Sharing an entrée in general is a great way to be able to eat out affordably.

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3. Open mic night

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This is basically a no-brainer. Most of these I've been to are either at a hall where you pay a minimum donation, or a club or coffeehouse where you can go for drinks-only. Hey, it's cheaper than a hundred-dollar dinner

out, right? Order a pitcher of draft and share it with another couple on a double date.

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4. Stroll and snack

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This one can be successfully modified for a variety of situations. Beach walk and an ice cream, cruising the piazza while sharing a portable panini, or sharing a hot giant pretzel while walking the street performers' circuit are just a few ideas.

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5. Picnic in the park

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Before you assume this can only be humdrum, here are a few ideas. First, pair the picnic with some form of free entertainment such as Shakespeare under the stars, a free concert, public dance performance, children's theater presentation, etc. Next, put some effort into planning the picnic menu so it will feel like more of a date. Wine, cheese, and bread with sliced fruit; biscotti and iced coffee with pressed sandwiches . . . you get the idea. A plateau overlooking Petra in Jordan and the piazza in Pisa, Italy, are a couple of memorable picnics for our family.

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6. Camping

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Since you are doing this as a date, get a great campground in a fun location